

Yuexuan Xu, MPP, PhD

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The Gertrude H. Sergievsky Center · Taub Institute for Research on Alzheimer's Disease and the Aging Brain
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RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research focuses on elucidating the genetic and molecular mechanisms underlying Alzheimer's disease, with an emphasis on disease heterogeneity, molecular subtyping, and genomic and multi-omic risk prediction across diverse populations. I integrate large-scale genetic and genomic epidemiology studies with multi-omic data—including transcriptomic, metabolomic, proteomic, and epigenomic profiles—and biomarker measures such as plasma and CSF analytes to characterize biologically distinct disease pathways, improve early disease detection, and refine risk stratification. My work also examines gene-environment interactions and applies advanced statistical and machine learning approaches to identify disease subtypes and predict longitudinal cognitive and disease trajectories. The broader goal of my research is to advance precision medicine by improving the identification, prediction, and biological characterization of heterogeneous forms of Alzheimer's disease and related dementias. A defining niche of my research is the integration of multi-ancestry genetics, molecular biomarkers, and multi-omic data to disentangle biologically distinct forms of dementia and connect genetic susceptibility with heterogeneity in pathology and disease progression.

EDUCATION

2019–2023	Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) Concentration: Statistics, Quantitative Genetics, and Genetic Epidemiology University of Wisconsin-Madison (Madison, WI, USA) Dissertation: <i>"Identification of Life-Course Gene-Environment Interactions in Cognitive Decline During Preclinical Alzheimer's"</i> Advisor: Dr. Corinne Engelman
2016–2018	Master of Public Policy (M.P.P.) Concentration: Social Science Genomics University of Southern California (Los Angeles, CA, USA)
2011–2015	Bachelor's Degree (Management) Shandong University (Jinan, Shandong, China)

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

2024–Present	Postdoctoral Research Scientist (Mentor: Dr. Richard Mayeux) The Gertrude H. Sergievsky Center Taub Institute for Research on Alzheimer's Disease and the Aging Brain Columbia University (New York, NY, USA)
2024–Present	Honorary Associate Department of Population Health Sciences University of Wisconsin-Madison (Madison, WI, USA)
2020–2023	Research Assistant (Mentor: Dr. Corinne Engelman) Department of Population Health Sciences University of Wisconsin-Madison (Madison, WI, USA)
2019–2020	Research Assistant (Mentor: Dr. Jason Fletcher) Center for Demography of Health and Aging University of Wisconsin-Madison (Madison, WI, USA)
2018–2019	Research Specialist (PI: Dr. Titus Galama) Center for Economic and Social Research University of Southern California (Los Angeles, CA, USA)
2018	Teaching Assistant (Instructor: Dr. John Romley) Sol Price School of Public Policy University of Southern California (Los Angeles, CA, USA)

PUBLICATIONS

Preprints

1. **Xu Y**, Sun Z, Jonaitis E, Deming Y, Lu Q, Johnson SC, Engelman CD. Mid-to-Late Life Healthy Lifestyle Modifies Genetic Risk for Longitudinal Cognitive Aging among Asymptomatic Individuals. *medRxiv* [Preprint]. 2024 May 27:2024.05.26.24307953. doi: 10.1101/2024.05.26.24307953. PMID: 38853902; PMCID: PMC11160812.

Peer-Reviewed Articles

1. **Xu Y**, Gunasekaran TI, Gu Y, Reyes-Dumeyer D, Piriz A, Sanchez D, Mejia DR, Medrano M, Lantigua RA, Alzheimer's Disease Neuroimaging Initiative, Honig L, Wilson R, Reyes RER, Manly JJ, Brickman AM, Engelman CD, Johnson S, Asthana S, Bennett DA, Petersen M, O'Bryant S, Vardarajan BN, Mayeux R. Plasma phosphorylated tau 217 concentrations, APOE genotype, and timing of cognitive impairment in individuals across diverse racial and ethnic groups: a pooled analysis of prospective cohort studies. *Lancet Neurol*. 2026 Sep 9. doi: 10.1016/S1474-4422(26)00313-3. [Epub ahead of print] PMID: 42716078.
2. **Xu Y**, Qiao M, Gunasekaran TI, Gu Y, Reyes-Dumeyer D, Piriz A, Sanchez D, Soriano B, Franco Y, Coronado ZD, Recio P, Mejia DR, Medrano M, Lantigua RA, Honig L, Wilson R, Manly JJ, Brickman AM, Engelman CD, Johnson S, Asthana S, Vardarajan B, Mayeux R. Polygenic scores of Core 1 Alzheimer's disease biomarkers predict early cognitive and pathological change. *Alzheimers Dement*. 2025 Nov;21(11):e70937. doi: 10.1002/alz.70937. PMID: 41307156; PMCID: PMC12658386.
3. **Xu Y**, Qiao M, Gunasekaran TI, Gu Y, Reyes-Dumeyer D, Piriz A, Sanchez D, Soriano B, Franco Y, Coronado ZD, Recio P, Mejia DR, Medrano M, Lantigua RA, Honig L, Manly JJ, Brickman AM, Vardarajan BN, Mayeux R. Evaluating polygenic risk score prediction performance for Alzheimer's disease in a population-based Hispanic cohort using single- and multi-ancestry models. *Lancet Reg Health Am*. 2025 Jul 25;49:101198. doi: 10.1016/j.lana.2025.101198. PMID: 40747112; PMCID: PMC12312067.
4. **Xu Y**, Sun Z, Jonaitis E, Deming Y, Lu Q, Johnson SC, Engelman CD. Apolipoprotein E moderates the association between non-APOE polygenic risk score for Alzheimer's disease and aging on preclinical cognitive function. *Alzheimers Dement*. 2024 Feb;20(2):1063–1075. doi: 10.1002/alz.13515. Epub 2023 Oct 19. PMID: 37858606; PMCID: PMC10916952.
5. **Xu Y**, Vasiljevic E, Deming YK, Jonaitis EM, Kosciak RL, Van Hulle CA, Lu Q, Carboni M, Kollmorgen G, Wild N, Carlsson CM, Johnson SC, Zetterberg H, Blennow K, Engelman CD. Effect of Pathway-Specific Polygenic Risk Scores for Alzheimer's Disease (AD) on Rate of Change in Cognitive Function and AD-Related Biomarkers Among Asymptomatic Individuals. *J Alzheimers Dis*. 2023;94(4):1587–1605. doi: 10.3233/JAD-230097. PMID: 37482996; PMCID: PMC10468904.

SEMINAR (INVITED) TALKS

- 2023 “Beyond the Surface: Reassessing Genes, Environment, and their Interaction in the Preclinical Stage of Alzheimer's.”
Department of Psychiatry and Behavioral Sciences, UCSF
Department of Population Health Sciences and Epidemiology, Stanford
Department of Genetics and Genomic Sciences, Icahn School of Medicine

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Abstracts

- 2026 “Pathology-Informed Polygenic Scores Identify Distinct Genetic Contributors to Alzheimer's and Non-Alzheimer's Dementia Across Ancestries.” Accepted for poster presentation at the Clinical Trials on Alzheimer's Disease Conference 2026, Boston, MA, USA.
- “Plasma P-tau217 and APOE Genotype Can Predict Onset of Cognitive Impairment Before the Diagnosis of Alzheimer's Disease.” Accepted for oral presentation at the Clinical Trials on Alzheimer's Disease Conference 2026, Boston, MA, USA.
- “Pathology-Informed Polygenic Scores Identify Distinct Genetic Contributors to Alzheimer's and Non-Alzheimer's Dementia Across Ancestries.” Accepted for poster presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2026, London, UK.
- “Plasma P-tau217 and APOE Genotype Can Predict Onset of Cognitive Impairment Before the Diagnosis of Alzheimer's Disease.” Accepted for oral presentation at the AD/PD Conference 2026, Copenhagen, Denmark.

2025	<i>"Polygenic scores of Core 1 Alzheimer's disease biomarkers predict early cognitive and pathological change."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2025, Toronto, Canada. <i>"Polygenic scores of Core 1 Alzheimer's disease biomarkers predict early cognitive and pathological change."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the AD/PD Conference 2025, Vienna, Austria.
2024	<i>"Evaluating polygenic risk score prediction performance for Alzheimer's disease in a population-based Hispanic cohort using single- and multi-ancestry models."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the American Society for Human Genetics Annual Conference 2024, Denver, CO, USA. <i>"Sex Differences in the Risk of Alzheimer's Disease and Associated Risk Factors Among Aging Hispanics: A Cross-country Study."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2024, Philadelphia, PA, USA. <i>"Non-APOE Polygenic risk score derived from European ancestry data are more predictive of dementia among Hispanics who are APOE ϵ4 carriers."</i> Accepted for oral presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2024, Philadelphia, PA, USA.
2023	<i>"Childhood self-reported socioeconomic status modifies the genetic risk of Alzheimer's on mid- and late-life cognitive decline in a population-based study."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2023, Amsterdam, Netherlands. <i>"Childhood self-reported socioeconomic status modifies the genetic risk of Alzheimer's on mid- and late-life cognitive decline in a population-based study."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Society for Epidemiology Annual Conference 2023, Portland, OR, USA.
2022	<i>"Mid-to-Late Life Healthy Lifestyle Modifies Genetic Risk for Longitudinal Cognitive Aging among Asymptomatic Individuals from the Wisconsin Registry for Alzheimer's Prevention."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Wisconsin Alzheimer's Disease Research Day 2023, Madison, WI, USA. <i>"Mid-to-Late Life Healthy Lifestyle Modifies Genetic Risk for Longitudinal Cognitive Aging among Asymptomatic Individuals from the Wisconsin Registry for Alzheimer's Prevention."</i> Accepted for oral presentation at the Synergies for Longitudinal Study Conference, Madison, WI, USA. <i>"Mid-to-Late Life Healthy Lifestyle Modifies Genetic Risk for Longitudinal Cognitive Aging among Asymptomatic Individuals from the Wisconsin Registry for Alzheimer's Prevention."</i> Accepted for oral presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2022, San Diego, CA, USA. <i>"Apolipoprotein E moderates the association between Non-APOE Polygenic Risk Score for Alzheimer's Disease and Aging on Preclinical Cognitive Function."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Alzheimer's Association International Conference 2022, San Diego, CA, USA. <i>"Apolipoprotein E moderates the association between Non-APOE Polygenic Risk Score for Alzheimer's Disease and Aging on Preclinical Cognitive Function."</i> Accepted for poster presentation at the Wisconsin Alzheimer's Disease Research Day 2022, Madison, WI, USA.
2021	<i>"Effect of Pathway-specific Polygenic Risk Scores for Alzheimer's Disease on Rate of Change in Cognitive Function and AD-related Biomarkers among Asymptomatic Individuals."</i> Accepted for oral presentation at the Integrating Genetics into the Social Sciences Conference 2021, Boulder, CO, USA.
2020	<i>"Bald is Beautiful? Life course outcomes for individuals at high genetic risk for male pattern baldness."</i> Accepted for oral presentation at the Integrating Genetics into the Social Sciences Conference 2020, Boulder, CO, USA.

EXTERNAL TRAINING, CERTIFICATES, AND WORKSHOPS

2022	Novel models for longitudinal continuous outcomes workshop Stanford University
2021	DNA methylation analysis workshop University of Colorado-Boulder
2020	Statistical workshop on genomic family data University of Colorado-Boulder
2020	Genome-wide data analyses Tinbergen Institute and University of Wisconsin-Madison

GRANT SUPPORT

2027–2032	Principal Investigator <i>Clinical- and Biomarker-Informed Multi-Ancestry, Multi-Omic Prediction and Molecular Subtyping of Alzheimer's Disease</i> NIH/NIA K99/R00 Pathway to Independence Award Status: Pending Role: PI
2022–2023	Project Lead (Faculty PI: Corinne Engelman) <i>Gene-Environment Interactions in Cognitive Decline During Preclinical Alzheimer's</i> UW-Madison CDHA pilot project award, NIH P30AG017266 Status: Funded Role: Conceived the project, wrote the funded proposal, and led the research as my dissertation project. Total costs: \$50,000

HONORS/AWARDS

2021, 2023	Graduate Student Research Competition Grant University of Wisconsin-Madison
2022	Rankin / Skatrud Research Award University of Wisconsin-Madison
2019	Chancellor's Fellowship University of Wisconsin-Madison
2019	PHS Outstanding Student Scholarship University of Wisconsin-Madison
2018	Phi Alpha Alpha National Honor Society (inducted in 2018) Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs, and Administration
2015	Outstanding Undergraduate Thesis Award Shandong University
2013	Scholarship for Academic Excellence Shandong University

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2017–2018	Part-time policy analyst (Master's Practicum / Capstone Project) International Refugee Assistance Project
Summer 2017	Policy analyst intern Fudan University PPIR Center

MEDIA COVERAGE & RESEARCH FEATURES

2026	Newsweek — <i>Alzheimer's Test Could Reveal When Symptoms May Begin Years in Advance</i> September 2026 (https://www.newsweek.com/alzheimers-test-could-reveal-when-symptoms-may-begin-years-in-advance-12447970) International Business Times Australia — <i>New Blood and Gene Test Combo Can Predict Alzheimer's Symptoms Years Before They Appear, Study Finds</i> September 2026 (https://www.ibtimes.com.au/blood-test-apoe4-predict-alzheimers-symptoms-1875571) News-Medical — <i>APOE Genotype Helps p-tau217 Predict Who May Develop Cognitive Impairment Sooner</i> September 2026 (https://www.news-medical.net/news/20260914/APOE-genotype-helps-p-tau217-predict-who-may-develop-cognitive-impairment-sooner.aspx) Commonwealth Union — <i>Can a Blood Test Predict Alzheimer's Before Memory Loss Begins? New Study Offers Clues</i> September 2026 (https://www.commonwealthunion.com/can-a-blood-test-predict-alzheimers-before-memory-loss-begins-new-study-offers-clues/) ALLATRA Media — <i>A Gene Result Changes What an Alzheimer's Blood Test Can Tell You</i> September 2026 (https://allatra.media/news/science-ptau217-apoe-timing-of-cognitive-impairment) Medical Xpress — <i>Blood and Gene Tests Predict Alzheimer's Symptoms Three to Six Years Ahead</i> September 2026 (https://medicalxpress.com/news/2026-09-blood-gene-alzheimer-symptoms-years.html)
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Columbia University Irving Medical Center — *Blood Biomarker and Genetic Test May Help Predict Timing of Cognitive Impairment* | September 2026 (<https://www.neurology.columbia.edu/news/blood-biomarker-and-genetic-test-may-help-predict-timing-cognitive-impairment>)

Science — *An Alzheimer's Blood Test Is Getting Popular. But Who Really Needs It?* | March 2026 (<https://www.science.org/content/article/alzheimer-s-blood-test-getting-popular-who-really-needs-it>)

TaubCONNECT Research Perspectives: October 2025
<https://columbianeuroresearch.org/taub/res-taub-connect-10-2025.html#4>

TaubCONNECT Research Perspectives: December 2025
<https://columbianeuroresearch.org/taub/res-taub-connect.html>

2025

PEER REVIEW SERVICE

Scientific Report; Journal of Alzheimer's Disease; Journal of Alzheimer's Disease Report; Brain, Behavior, and Immunity – Health; International Journal of Molecular Sciences; Dementia and Geriatric Cognitive Disorders; International Journal of Geriatric Psychiatry.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

International Society to Advance Alzheimer's Research and Treatment
Society for Epidemiologic Studies
International Genetic Epidemiology Society

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Nationality:	People's Republic of China
Software:	R, SAS, STATA, Arc-GIS, PLINK, GCTA, LDSC
Programming languages:	R (proficient), Python (proficient)
Computational environment:	High-performance computing (HPC) on Linux-based clusters (Slurm) for large-scale genomic and biomarker analyses
NCBI Bibliography:	ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/myncbi/yuexuan.xu.3/bibliography/public/

REFERENCES

Richard Mayeux, MS, MD

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